

groponte, OLPC's founder, does not end up manufacturing the XO-3, at least this futuristic design is likely to kindle the imagination of other computer manufacturers and push them to manufacture more low-cost, education-focused models.

A device thinner than the iPhone, with a virtual keyboard and no buttons; a sleek touch screen framed by a stylish green gasket; a durable, all-plastic, waterproof body; an 8-gigahertz (GHz) processor; power consumption less than a watt; chargerless operation with a battery that recharges itself by induction; and a price tag of \$75—the design does seem highly innovative, but let us wait till 2012 to see if production goes on as planned and if they can at all match the promised price!

2 The new face of change: Waveface

ASUS has showcased a futuristic concept called Waveface, with the goal of providing true anytime, anywhere connectivity and location-based services. Three vapourware devices were presented at CES 2010: the Waveface Casa, Waveface Light and Waveface Ultra.

Targeted at home users, the Waveface Casa is a large-screen, Internet-enabled television and entertainment centre. It comes with a flexible cover capable of hiding however much of the screen you wish to hide, for the sake of aesthetics. You could leave just a small portion of the screen open to view the news ticker, weather report, stock market update or the scores!



ASUS WaveFace Ultra

What do you mean by 'ultra-portable'?

"The classification of computers as portable or ultra-portable is highly subjective in the sense that there are no fixed technical specifications that would define it. However, we would define 'portable' as devices that are designed around the ease of use that they provide to the user as a result of their diminished form factors. Ultra-portable laptops, on the other hand, are not just great lookers but also pack in all the typical features a mainstream notebook would contain. Typically, ultra-portable laptops weigh less than 1.5 kg and, when closed, are 3.8cm thin or thinner. They are likely to have smaller keyboards and lighter batteries for better portability," explains Amar Babu, managing director, Lenovo India.

Why do I need an ultra-portable when I have a smart phone?

"While smart phones are the most portable pocket devices, these come with their share of limitations. However easy and intuitive the computing experience is made on a mobile phone, the process tends to become cumbersome in the long run due to the restrictive keyboards and relatively minuscule displays. Hence, smart phones are usually forced to compromise on certain essential functionalities. Unlike smart phones, ultra-portable PCs offer a wider feature set to the user for a comparatively better price. Ultra-portable PCs support more complex computational tasks, owing to more powerful processors. At the core of the design of both mobile phones and ultra-portable PCs lies their prime function. In this case, the concept of 'one-size-fits-all' would not work as the two categories cater to different sets of consumers. As the two occupy independent niches in the mobile computing space, we feel that ultra-portable PCs would always retain their edge and popularity with their customer base," says Amar Babu.

The Waveface Light, on the other hand, is a light-weight tablet designed for cloud computing. With a foldable screen and a tactile on-screen keyboard, it can be used either as a tablet or as a laptop.

The third concept, Ultra, is an ultra-portable wearable computer that can be worn like a watch. You can hold it flat to get a full view or twist it and wear it when you need to see only a small part of the screen at a time.

It might be a few years before these devices are ready for production, but just the concept is likely to make a gadget-freak drool.

3 Tabby convertibles

It seems to be the season of hybrid devices. There were quite a few samples at the CES held in January this year.

Lenovo showcased its hybrid laptop—believed to be an industry-first. The IdeaPad U1 hybrid notebook has a detachable touch screen that can be removed and used as a tablet PC. The screen also has a processor and



Lenovo IdeaPad U1 hybrid notebook

an operating system, enabling it to act as an independent device. It clubs the functionality of a notebook with the convenience of a slate-style, multi-touch tablet.

What is more, the benefits of both processors can be clubbed and the two devices can work as one, sharing battery power, 3G wireless, data and documents. Lenovo's Hybrid Switch technology enables seamless toggling between the two processors. You can use the machine in its laptop form,